

TCS and HDFC) hire around 500 people a month, and so do others such as Daksh and Wipro Spectramind.

As Jaipal Verma, Manager-HR, eServe, says, "Four years ago, there was hardly a call centre around worth its name. Today... the demand for them has increased." The numbers are large—but do the companies get the right candidates?

An HR Executive from 3 Global Services Pvt Ltd, a call centre division of Hutchison Whampoa Limited, confirms, "We get the quantity, not the quality, and so recruitment numbers seem large." Verma lists the skills that a call centre or BPO would look for: "Good communication skills, fluency in English, diction and the most important attribute—customer oriented behaviour." Raamann Kumar, Senior Manager-HR, Intelenet, says, "It is a misconception that call centres look for accented English; in fact, we look for people with a neutral accent." These jobs let undergraduates augment their pocket money and get work experience. So, is a call centre ideal to begin one's career?

Kumar gives an example of an employee who began with Intelenet as a Customer Service Executive, and three years down, she is Manager-Training. But she might belong to a small tribe who look at a call centre as a career option. For the majority, call centres are a temporary halt.

Looking in the right places

Most IT and ITES companies have a recruitment strategy encompassing press advertisements, online job sites, placement consultants and employee referrals. The company Web site is an important tool for any recruiter, according to Microsoft's Pruthwi. He says 25 per cent of applicants to Microsoft used the company's Web site to apply and expects this to go up by 25 per cent in the coming years.

Though the best way to create company awareness, press ads are expensive. Here's where job sites come in. For the last five years, a number of them—naukri.com, timesjobs.com etc, have become the preferred option for job seekers. Arijit Sen, Manager-Marketing, Customer Care and Operations, Jobstreet.com India, says, "The IT sector has adapted to e-recruitment the most. It's use in this sector is the highest. Over 50 per cent of jobs on such Web sites in India come from this sector." Hitesh



A N PRUTHWI,
Staffing Manager, India
Microsoft

“We are witnessing a period peak of 1998-2000—the dotcom phase; by 2005 we would hit that stage and go beyond”

Is IT or Not?

“I graduated in MCA in the ill-fated year of 2001. Campus placements did not materialise. Now, when the industry is looking up, companies either want freshers or experience.” People like me have to struggle to get jobs.

S VANITHA

SOFTWARE DEVELOPER SOFTLAND

SOFTWARE SOLUTIONS PVT LTD, BANGALORE

“Despite clearing interviews, I am rejected for my background; they (IT companies) assume I am not a technical guy.”

KARAN CHAUHAN,

BIO-MEDICAL ENGINEERING GRADUATE 2002

MUMBAI

Bhartia, Manager, Mumbai Operations, also confirms that for a job seeker as well as for an employer, the reach is wider. Sen says the most popular ones are from the one to eight years experience category.

However, both IT companies and call centres exercise caution. For a call centre, a walk-in is far better than an online résumé, as soft skills need to be checked; while an IT company always runs the danger of being swamped with junk résumés.

Placement consultants are an important link for e-recruitment. Kavita Iyer, a senior consultant with CAPNTEL Executive Search says, "A placement consultant helps in assessing the candidate prima facie." A manager with a leading software company also agrees that placement consultants are better because they are able to pitch for the candidate, to get him or her the best deal possible, and also look at cross-industry options. A placement consultant is your best bet when looking for a suitable change after a certain number of years of experience.

And Finally...

"There is no substitute for preparation; set your goals and work towards them," says Pruthwi, when asked about pointers for those who want to make it big in IT. Yes, there is a boom in both the IT and ITES sector, and recruitments would continue for more than two years at the least. For those who want to do well, accept that IT is a field of continuous learning—keep yourself updated because, like technology, knowledge, too, can become obsolete. □

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TIPS

Tips on writing a good résumé

- **Always state a job objective:** Decide on a job objective that can be expressed in about five or six lines.
- **Stick to a certain chronology:** Preferably, begin from the most recent.
- **Educational qualifications:** In case of experienced candidates, educational qualifications can be mentioned at the end, but for a fresher, this section is paramount and so should be on top.
- **Use strong verbs to highlight your**

achievements: Use verbs such as 'handled', 'headed', 'co-ordinated' and adjectives such as 'responsible', 'in-charge'. Be honest about your claims—all of what you write should be verifiable with your former employer.

- **Include hobbies and interests:** Things you really like doing. Just saying 'reading' would be very general; be more specific about such things so you can answer questions better during the interview stage.

- **References:** Give references only if asked.